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每周精选

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Bloomberg

扫码听音频 新英文课堂

Technology

July 27, 2022 | 539 words ›

Why Facebook, Instagram Look Like TikTok

The social network is overhauling itself to chase a faster-growing competitor, again.
v. 全面改革（制度或方法）

美国互联网科技公司，旗下有facebook、ins等社交软件　扎克伯格，facebook创始人 Meta董事长

Meta Platforms Inc. Chief Executive Officer Mark Zuckerberg made an announcement on July 21 that was confusing and somewhat misleading. In a Facebook post, he said he was breaking the social network's feed into two sections. Because users care so much about content from their friends and families, Zuckerberg said, those posts would get their own tab. But when users open the app, they won't see that tab but the one featuring Facebook's "discovery engine," which features content chosen by Meta's algorithms.

CEO，（大公司的）总裁、首席执行官

feed流：持续更新并呈现给用户内容的信息流

tab标签

FB发现引擎，用户在App内信息流中将会被推荐大量的来自未关注账户的内容

本句结构：It didn't take ... to see ...,真正主语：to see what Facebook was doing

It didn't take much reading between the lines to see what Facebook was doing: copying

字里行间；言外之意；找出段落之中的隐含之意

TikTok, the video-sharing app that it increasingly sees as its main competitor. The friends-and-family stuff that Facebook has built its empire on is going to become less accessible as Meta experiments with showing users content from people they aren't following. In theory, doing this could allow Facebook to refine its own version of TikTok's famously effective
v.(逐步)改进，完善
algorithms for choosing content, helping it retain users. Meta's Instagram is also redesigning its app so videos take over the full screen, like they do on TikTok.

Kylie Jenner has been critical of Instagram's latest changes.

一款"阅后即焚"照片分享应用
Copycatting is a familiar Meta strategy; the company's been launching Snapchat-inspired
v.抄袭，模仿
Ins"阅后即焚"功能
features for almost a decade. In 2016, Instagram finally developed a hit with Stories, the
n.功能
n.风行一时的事物
posts that last only 24 hours. The app has continued to mimic Snapchat, adding augmented-
v.学...的样子，模仿
AR，增强现实
reality face animations for selfies, messages that can disappear, and a searchable map. Meta
n.动画；（通过动画制作的）图像或特效
Ins推出的一款短视频应用
has also copied TikTok, as with Instagram's short-form video product, Reels, introduced in 2020.

Zuckerberg downplayed the significance of the recent change with users, but altering the
v.淡化...的重要性，对...轻描淡写
Facebook and Instagram algorithms—with the goal of achieving what another company is better at—is its biggest shift yet.

The change will affect the entire ecosystem of businesses, content creators, and regular people who use these platforms. The value of an Instagram influencer's large follower list goes down if those people aren't as likely to see their content. Same goes for a Facebook business page. Those who depend on the networks to be seen might have to start making Reels.

同样适用于

Meta isn't doing this to hurt creators, the people who make online content. It needs them. The changes to Instagram and Facebook may undercut the advantages of established influencers, but they could also be appealing to new creators who are having success on TikTok. On July 25, Meta also announced a way for video makers to split advertising profits on content that uses songs the company has licensed. And Meta has been encouraging people to make Reels by splitting a pool of bonus money with those who get the most views.

v.削弱；使降低效率 a.资深的 有吸引力的 v.均分、分配 v.授权、批准 n.共用的资源（或资金）

Some influencers aren't pleased with the algorithm updates. The reality stars and entrepreneurs Kylie Jenner and Kim Kardashian recently reshared a post begging Instagram to "stop trying to be TikTok." Jenner is the most followed woman, with 360 million followers; Kardashian has 326 million. "I just want to see cute photos of my friends," the post says. "PLEASEEEEEEE," Jenner commented.

n.(目的为娱乐，而非提供信息的)真人真事电视节目

Zuckerberg is betting that posts from friends and family aren't actually what users want to see, no matter how much they care about them. If it were, they could have stayed on Instagram or Facebook instead of migrating to TikTok in the first place. ■

虚拟用法，即用户想看亲朋好友发的贴子 表示本可以停留但是没有停留 一开始，起初

Los Angeles Times

扫码听音频 新英文课堂

Opinion

JULY 15, 2022 | 741 words ›

For crisis response, press 988 — and pass a bill to keep it funded

Pre A landmark unarmed crisis response alternative to 911 is about to go online across the U.S. without guarantees of funding to keep it going. 一项类似911的非武装紧急援助机制即将在美国各地上线，该项目具有里程碑意义，但缺乏资金支持

迪迪赫希心理健康服务中心

Carolyn Levitan is director of the Didi Hirsch Mental Health Services crisis line in Los Angeles. The organization is designated to handle calls to the new 988 crisis response number that goes live on July 16, 2022.

n.电话线（路）
v.(为某项工作或目的)任命、指派、选定
启动、上线

1 In the future, there will be a number to call for help, much like 911, yet different. It will be like a suicide crisis line, but better. On the other end of the line will be trained and experienced counselors adept at assisting people in the midst of mental health crises. They will be able to field questions and offer resources to families and friends concerned for the

n.顾问，参事 a.内行的，熟练的
在...当中，正当...的时候
v.处理，应付（问题、电话

well-being of their loved ones. Their real-time, over-the-phone emergency counseling skills
a.即时处理的，实时的
will be enhanced by a kind of superpower: They will be able to dispatch mental health clinicians, instead of police officers with guns or paramedics with trauma equipment.
n.临床医师 n.(非医生或者护士的)护理人员，医务辅助人员 n.外伤

2 And those on-the-ground experts will have an appropriate place to take people in crisis. Not
现场的，实地的 ad.专程，特意 v.接纳、接待（顾客、患者等）
jail, not the hospital, but centers geared expressly for meeting the needs of people
gear for：使做好准备
experiencing an emotional, psychological or substance-use breakdown. n.精神崩溃
物质使用不当，这里的物质一般指精神作用性药物

3 The number will be short and as easy to remember. It will work anywhere in the United States. It will be linked with 911 and the current national suicide prevention hotline, so that operators picking up any of those lines will be able to seamlessly transfer callers to the right
接电话 a.流畅的，浑然一体的
responders depending on need.

4 This new number is an integral part of the future imagined by activists for better mental
a.(构成整体所)必需的，必不可少的
health care, fewer unnecessary police shootings and an alternative response system that
行为医学
recognizes the difference between crime-fighting and behavioral health care.

The number is 988. And the future begins Saturday when the nationwide system goes live.

5 There's been little fanfare, and that may be a good thing at this early stage. Under federal
n.(与某一事件有关的)喧闹，广告，热议
legislation adopted in 2020, implementation is left to the states, which must come up with
n.贯彻，执行
funding to keep the phone response operating and to ensure there are people to answer the calls and respond in person. Few states have identified enough funding to keep the system
prep.(发生)在...之后，(延续)到...之后
afloat beyond the first few years.
a.有偿债能力，能维持下去keep (sth./sb.) afloat/stay afloat

That includes California. Federal pandemic-era largesse will be enough to launch the system
n.慷慨解囊，施舍
here but not enough to keep it going past Year 3.

6 A modest fee on phone service, similar to the funding model for 911, would be sufficient.
a.不太大的，不很贵的
Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, a Democrat from Orinda, introduced the
n.议员 除了其他东西/地方/因素等 v.提交（新法案以供讨论）
appropriately named AB 988 last year to (among other things) authorize a surcharge
988法案，AB时Assembly Bill的缩写法案全称：the Miles Hall Lifeline and Suicide Prevention Act n.附加费，额外费用

beginning at 8 cents a line per month.
v.(begin at)最低价格为，起步价为

It would be a wise investment. Mental health incidents too often are treated as crimes and turn what ought to be emergency help into deadly encounters.
n.(意外、突然或暴力的)相遇，冲突

7 It's noteworthy that Bauer-Kahan's bill is also called the Miles Hall Lifeline Act. Miles Hall was a 23-year-old man with a history of mental health challenges, living with his family in Walnut Creek. On June 2, 2019, as he was experiencing a mental health crisis, a family member called police for help. Officers responded, encountered Hall on the street near his home and shot him to death.

8 An estimated 25% of victims of police killings are dealing with psychiatric problems or are
a.精神病学的，精神病治疗的
otherwise mentally atypical, behaving in ways understandable to professionals familiar
a.非典型的，不同寻常的
with mental illness, autism, intellectual disability and other conditions but not to law
n.孤独症，自闭症 n.长期疾病
enforcement officers trained (and armed) principally to fight crime. In that sense the
ad.主要地
horrific Hall shooting was common.

9 988 is not merely a new number for an old suicide hotline, but is instead — or will be if handled properly — the kind of response system that mental health professionals, activists
Crisis Assistance Helping Out On The Streets
and even police say they want. Like the CAHOOTS program in Eugene, Ore., that became the
美国警察暴力执法
subject of nationwide discussion as an alternative to policing in the wake of the George
导致弗洛伊德死亡 (尤指不好的事)紧随某事而来；作为某事的后果
Floyd murder in Minneapolis, local and state programs linked to 988 can direct appropriate,
v.负责，管理，指导
non-police response where it's needed.

10 Los Angeles County is ahead of the curve in the sense that its 988 call center will be run by
领先
Didi Hirsch Mental Health Services, which has been providing crisis counseling since 1942. The organization already provides suicide lifeline services for L.A. County callers to the existing (but cumbersome) number, (800) 273-8255.
a.(话语或措词)冗长的，复杂的

11 The county, led by Supervisor Janice Hahn — a champion of alternative crisis response —
n.(美国某些地方政府中的)监督人 n.斗士，提倡者，捍卫者
supports the bill. Other California counties don't yet. That's shortsighted. 988 could be the

biggest and most positive change to the way government responds to emergencies since the first 911 call in 1968. The first step takes place this weekend, when the service goes live. In California, the second step should be to pass AB 988 into law. ■

pass into law：通过（使成为法律）

TIME

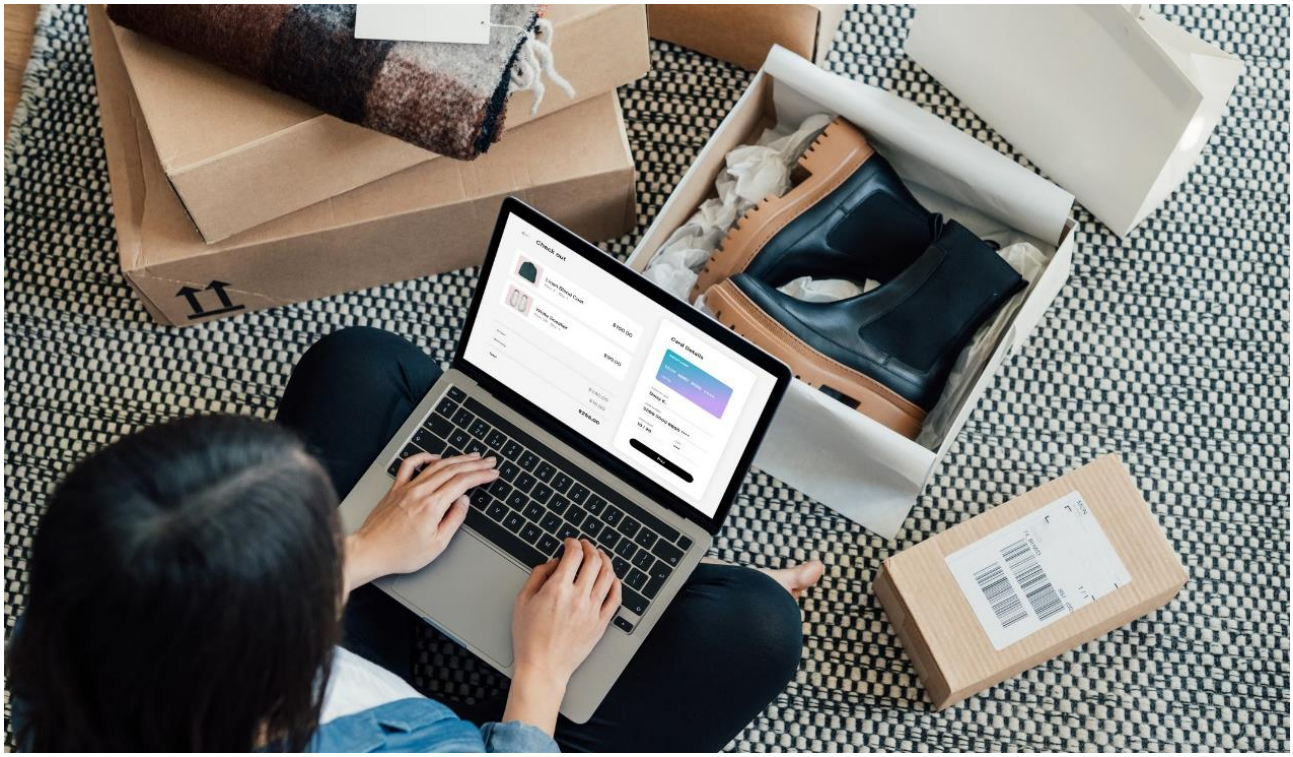
扫码听音频 新英文课堂

Health

JULY 26, 2022 | 759 words ›

Why Online Shopping Makes You So Happy

Online shopping is more than a hobby for those who get a thrill out of traversing the biggest mall in the world: the internet. It's also a sport.



Online shopping transformed from novelty to normality years ago: Amazon launched nearly three decades ago, in 1995, as an online bookseller, and now reports that customers buy around 7,400 products per minute from its U.S. sellers. But the pandemic shifted consumer habits in a way that favored buying even basic necessities like toilet paper online. According to the Annual Retail Trade Survey, e-commerce sales increased by $244 billion—or 43%—in 2020, jumping from $571 billion in 2019 to $815 billion in 2020.

That surge was at least partially driven by a desire to avoid indoor venues. But experts say

it could also have to do with self-soothing behaviors. Research has long suggested that retail therapy can actually be therapeutic. A study published in the *Journal of Consumer Psychology* in 2014, for example, indicates that making purchases helps people feel instantly happier—and also fights lingering sadness. One reason, the study authors speculate, is that making purchase decisions confers a sense of personal control and autonomy.

Another study, published in *Psychology & Marketing* in 2011, found that going shopping leads to "lasting positive impacts on mood," and is not associated with feelings of regret or guilt about spontaneous purchases.

Shopping is, in many ways, motivated by emotion, says Jorge Barraza, program director and assistant professor in the online master of science in applied psychology program at the University of Southern California. "When we're sad, when we're stressed, we're more likely to engage in this kind of behavior," he says. In some cases, he notes, the spark of joy a fancy new dress or gadget triggers might not last, especially if the buyer knows they're mismanaging their money. "That boost in mood might be transitory, if you're spending more than you can afford, but at least temporarily it does appear to restore a sense of control, and reduce any residual sadness that people might be experiencing."

Why online shopping makes people so happy

In many ways, online shopping catapults the pleasure of in-person shopping to a different, almost overwhelming stratosphere. "It's psychologically so powerful," says Joshua Klapow, a psychologist and adjunct associate professor of public health at the University of Alabama at Birmingham. (He's also the new owner of three inflatable pool floats, a collapsible whisk, two jars of almond butter, and 50 pounds of bird seed, all of which he ordered online.)

Compared to shopping in person, "it's a much more gratifying experience overall, because there's less friction, less barriers, less behavioral cost, more specificity, and more choice," he says. Plus, "the shopping is totally tailored to us. We can shop quickly or slowly."

Part of the reason why online shopping is so appealing is convenience. When we go

shopping in-person, Klapow points out, we have to walk or drive or figure out some other way of getting there, and then we have to stride through aisle after aisle to locate what we're looking for. Even at stores that offer contactless pay, there's some effort required to make a transaction: swiping a credit card or Apple Pay on your phone, for example. Then, a shopper needs to travel back home. "For a lot of people, these incredibly minor inconveniences just start picking away at the overall perceived value of the purchase," he says.

In addition to being easier, online shopping delivers the satisfaction of accuracy. If Klapow heads to a big-box store, he might not find the shirt he's looking for in the right size or color. If he's shopping online, he's more likely to snag exactly what he wants with far less hassle.

Doing so is a form of immediate gratification, which we're all wired to crave, says Joseph Kable, a cognitive neuroscience researcher at the University of Pennsylvania. "This is a tendency that's universal among people and is shared across much of the animal world," he says. "People and other animals tend to discount outcomes in the future, relative to outcomes that are immediate. This means we prefer to have good things as soon as possible, and to postpone bad things as far as possible in the future."

Interestingly, online shopping is also associated with another, more delayed type of gratification: anticipation for the order's arrival. Awaiting something exciting is "like Christmas every day," Klapow says, likening the ability to track a package to monitoring Santa's whereabouts on Christmas Eve. ■

The Economist

扫码听音频 新英文课堂

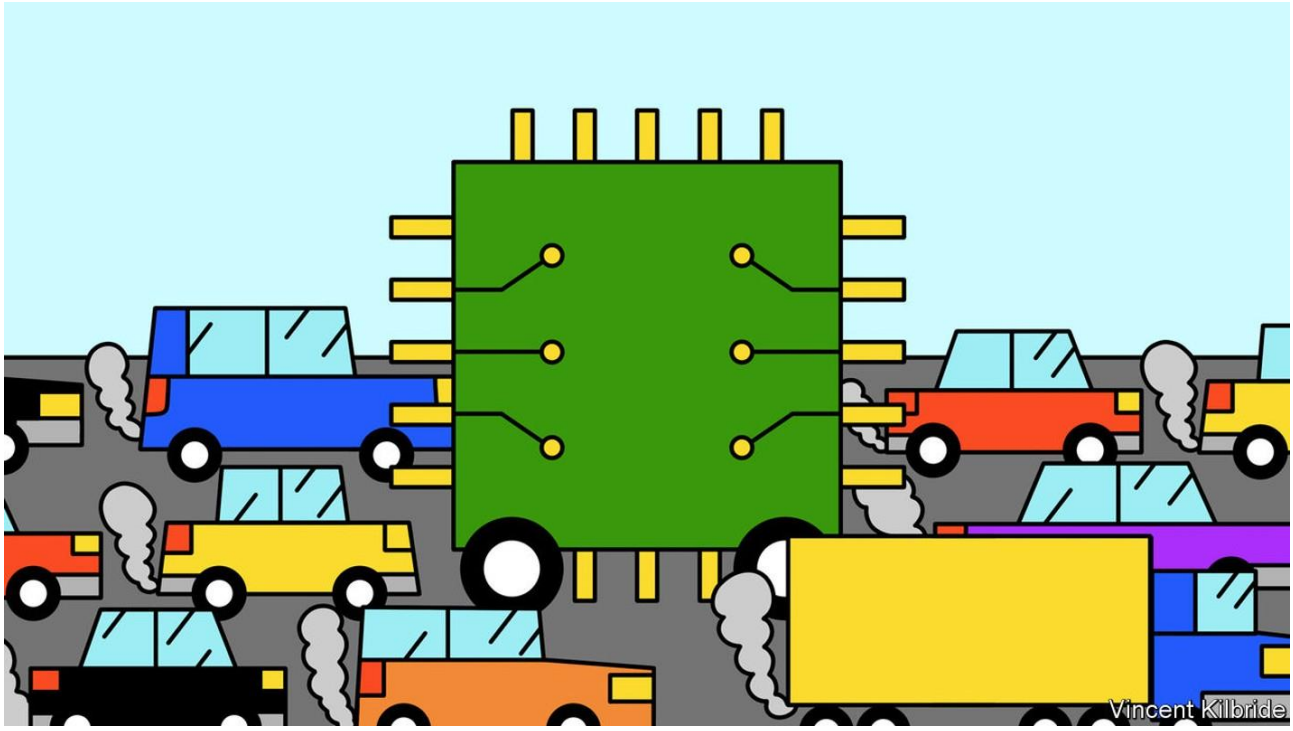
Leaders

Jul 27th 2022 | 775 words ›

Digital business

Cloudburst

The era of big-tech exceptionalism may be over



In the digital world, the laws of physics can be suspended on a programmer's whim. Equally, that world's corporate architects have seemed able to defy economic gravity. Since 2005 the digital share of American GDP has risen by a third, to 10%. America's tech oligopoly—Meta, Alphabet, Amazon, Microsoft and Apple (MAAMA, if you will)—has outpaced even that breakneck growth. Collectively, MAAMA's revenues and profits have swelled by nearly 20% a year on average over the past decade, while America eked out nominal annual GDP growth of less than 4%. Covid-19 may have cramped physical lives, but it enriched digital ones—thereby also enriching big tech as never before.

This year gravity has asserted itself once more. The tech-heavy NASDAQ index is down by a quarter since January, half as much again as America's broader stockmarket. Profitless not-so-big tech has been dragged down by anaemic revenue growth and high interest rates, which make the far-off earnings of firms like Snap look less valuable today. More surprising, despite generating piles of cash in the here and now, the giants are also feeling the tug of reality. On July 26th Alphabet reported its slowest quarterly sales growth since the bleak early months of the pandemic. Its share price rallied, though not enough to offset recent falls and only because expectations were even worse. A day later Meta said its sales fell year on year, for the first time ever.

America's technology titans are suddenly having to contend with forces that have long plagued old-economy CEOs: gummed-up supply chains, protectionism, worker shortages and competition. For MAAMA, these constraints are something of a novelty. Its bosses had better get used to them.

One limit is geography, often forgotten in a world of seamless global supply chains and largely borderless cyberspace. In so far as the tech giants peddle physical bits and bobs rather than digital bytes, they are sharing in the pain of supply disruptions. In April, Apple (which like Amazon was due to report its results after we went to press) warned that its revenues would be $4bn-8bn lower than expected in the second quarter, chiefly because of supply-chain snags in China, where factories are locked down with unnerving severity every time a case of covid turns up. Ingenious inventory-management software has not spared Amazon—which, like conventional retailers such as Walmart, misjudged what shoppers wanted and when—from extra costs.

Barriers are being put up on the internet, too, as places from the European Union to India become more protective of their citizens' data and of their own digital darlings. That is a worry for Alphabet, Meta and Microsoft, which, outside firewalledChina at least, face few barriers to selling their digital services.

Another limit has to do with talent. Tech firms are not used to scrabbling around for the best programmers. However, having dislodged banks and consultancies as graduates' dream employers, big tech is finding it hard to recruit. One reason is the sheer size of MAAMA's collective workforce, which has grown nearly seven-fold in the past ten years, to 2.2m. The bigger the payroll the harder it is to replenish, let alone expand. Big tech also faces stiffer competition from other industries, all of which these days manifest a degree of techiness minus the controversies that have sullied big tech's reputation.

The last limit is MAAMA's markets. As businesses such as e-commerce revert to pre-covid growth rates, the pandemic looks less like the start of an era of endless digitisation, and more like a one-off step-change. As they become commonplace, tech offerings are behaving like other staples. As Alphabet and Meta show, digital ads, once thought immune to the business cycle, may be turning as procyclical as the offline sort.

Be it online ads or shopping, the cloud or smartphones, tech markets are more mature—and mature markets grow more slowly, especially when regulators are no longer ignoring them. In many areas incumbents' fat margins are being competed down. Amazon, for example, is investing heavily in its advertising business, Alphabet's forte; Alphabet, meanwhile, is spending billions to get a foothold in the cloud, which is Amazon's.

MAAMA mia, can you grow again?

The giants of tech may yet rediscover their reality-distorting magic. Amazon's $3.9bn purchase this month of One Medical, an American health-care provider, is only the latest MAAMA effort to conquer one of the last remaining under-digitised markets big enough to move the needle for a trillion-dollar firm. They may once again conjure up an all-new market, as Apple did with the iPhone's app economy and hopes to repeat with augmented reality. Until that happens, though, the era of big-tech exceptionalism is probably over. ■

The Economist

扫码听音频 新英文课堂

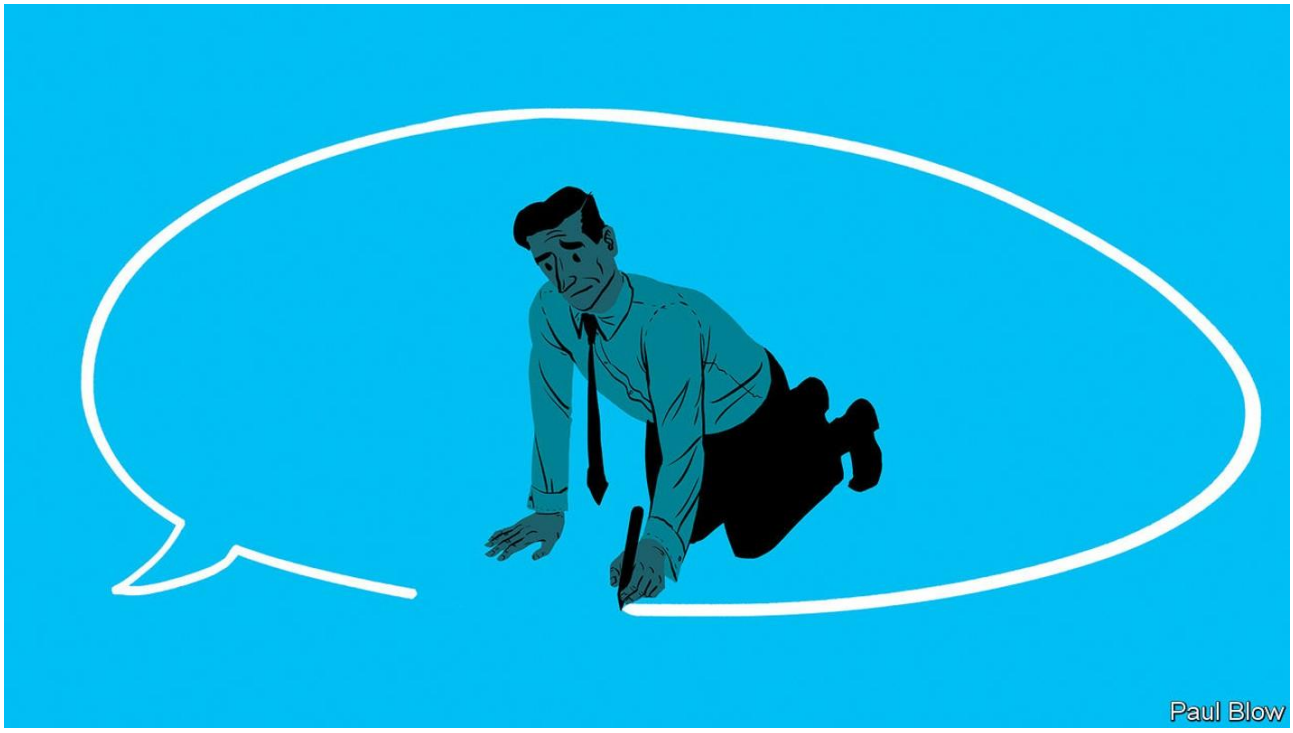
Business

Jul 28th 2022 | 730 words ›

Bartleby

The perils of perfectionism

A backlash against the tyranny of high expectations



It is the world's most tired interview question: what is your greatest weakness? And Rishi Sunak, one of the two remaining candidates in the race to become Britain's prime minister, gave the world's most tired answer—perfectionism—when he was asked it at an online hustings earlier this month.

No interviewee would answer this question with an unambiguous negative ("stupidity", say, or "body odour"). Like all those who have reached for it before, Mr Sunak will have intended his reply to signal that his flaws are virtues, especially compared with the shambolic style

of Boris Johnson's outgoing government.

But this classic response is riskier than it once was. In Mr Sunak's case that is because the job of prime minister is largely to triage problems and make decisions at a relentless pace; even his supporters worry that his deliberative style would be a problem. More generally, perfectionism is increasingly out of step with the ways that products are developed, employees are treated and workforces are organised.

Start with product development. Lots of digital types embrace the concept of the minimum viable product (MVP), in which companies ship prototypes that can be refined, or indeed scrapped, on the basis of feedback from early adopters. The essence of the MVP approach is anti-perfectionism: don't procrastinate, don't spend time sweating the tiniest details, get your product into users' hands and see how it does. Fussing about font sizes and nice-to-have features is a waste of time; the market will hone things for you, dispensing its judgments cumulatively and dispassionately.

A growing emphasis on employees' well-being is another reason why perfectionism is out of favour. The trait is on the rise: a study published in 2017 found that it had been steadily increasing among American, British and Canadian college students between 1989 and 2016 (before you blame Instagram, one big reason is rising parental expectations). The tyranny of excessively high expectations is not good for you: a big literature review in 2016 concluded that perfectionism is associated with a string of mental-health disorders, from depression and burnout to stress and self-harm.

It matters what kind of perfectionist someone is. Psychologists distinguish between a "self-oriented" version, in which people put pressure on themselves to perform flawlessly; an "other-oriented" type, in which people hold their colleagues to the highest of standards; and a "socially prescribed" version, in which employees think that they will only get on if they meet the impossible expectations of those around them. People in the last camp seem to be especially prone to stress. A recent Italian study found that, whereas having extremely high standards for your own performance was not a predictor of burnout, being afraid of making

mistakes was.

Perfectionists may also hurt team cohesiveness. In a study conducted in 2020, Emily Kleszewski and Kathleen Otto of Philipps-University of Marburg asked people to rate potential co-workers based on descriptions of their levels and categories of perfectionism. Perfectionists were regarded as being less socially skilled and less likeable than non-perfectionists. You don't have to like your colleagues for them to be effective: in that same study, perfectionists were rated as more competent than non-perfectionists. But when more and more work is organised around small groups working together, it can help not to loathe each other.

By now your inner curmudgeon may well be frothing at the mouth. Nit-picking micro-managers are deeply annoying but they are nowhere near as bad as people who don't have any standards. Demanding bosses can be the difference between good products and superb ones: "that'll do" was not the mantra that made Steve Jobs successful. Some jobs actively require perfectionism—copy editors, say, or medicines regulators. And since when did being exacting become a health risk?

Fortunately, discouraging perfectionism does not mean sacrificing high standards. In a paper published last year, three academics at the University of Ottawa found that people who strove for excellence did better on tests of creative thinking than people who sought perfection. Managers can explicitly define what counts as high-quality work. Deadlines can prevent endless procrastination. Mr Sunak's call not to let the perfect be the enemy of the good came as he sat in front of a poster that misspelled the word "campaign". That took things too far. ■

The Atlantic

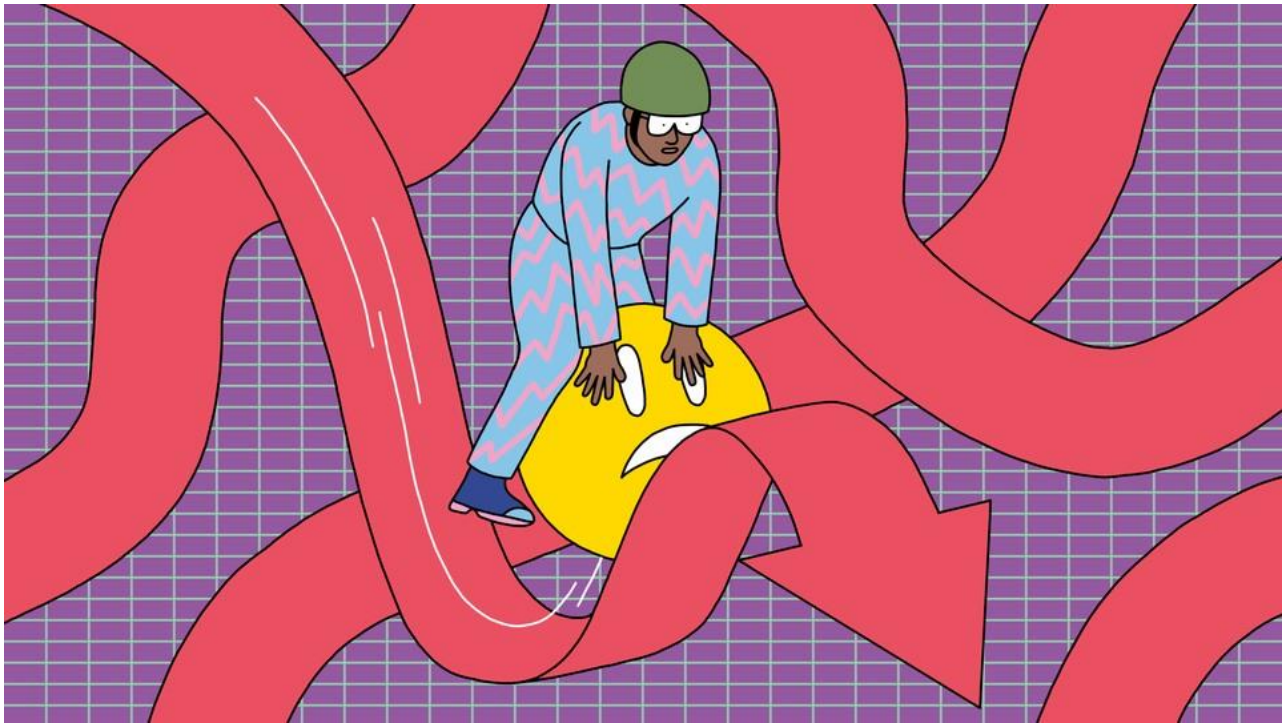
扫码听音频 新英文课堂

Family

JULY 28, 2022 | 900 words

How to Be Happy in a Recession

A financial downturn doesn't have to cause an emotional one.



After years of historically loose monetary policy, trillions of dollars in stimulus checks, and supply-chain wreckage during the coronavirus pandemic, perhaps we shouldn't be surprised that a recession is looming, and may already be upon us. But the fact that it is predictable doesn't make the high prices, effectively lower wages, and tanking investments hurt any less.

You might be forgoing discretionary purchases just to fill up your gas tank and buy groceries. Perhaps you are postponing your vacation, or rethinking a much-anticipated life change, such as getting married or moving. And although the job market looks good now, you might

be starting to feel nervous about that too.

Along with material security, many Americans are losing their sense of control over their economic fate. When stock markets are declining quickly, almost no amount of work can keep retirement savings from falling, swallowing up months and years of sacrifice. If you're a homeowner, knowing that your house is losing value comes with a special sense of helplessness.

The unhappiness that accompanies recession is real, and you're not irrational if you feel it. Your instincts might tell you to fight these bad feelings by focusing on the problem intently and managing your affairs meticulously. But that's not actually the best way to alleviate your suffering. To ride out the coming recession with your happiness intact, you'll need to figure out how to pay less attention than your brain is telling you to.

Not that you needed proof, but survey data show a strong link between happiness and the health of the economy. For example, researchers have found that the performance of the stock market affects Americans' well-being. And the relationship goes both ways. In 2016, economists analyzed the "happiness sentiment" expressed in about 10 percent of all English-language Twitter posts made each day from late 2008 to mid-2015 and compared it with the performance of 11 international stock markets. They found evidence that higher expressed happiness in tweets parallels stock returns, presumably because happier investors tend to buy shares instead of sell them. If happiness raises stock returns, and stock returns raise happiness, a feedback loop could easily fuel a bubble. Conversely, we can also see how an emotional funk can reinforce economic recession, and thus why slumps can be hard to break.

Unfortunately for us, bad economic times seem to have a bigger effect on mood than good times do, and losses tend to bring people down more than gains bring them up. This is the central conclusion of "prospect theory," an idea from the economics Nobel Laureate Daniel Kahneman and the late psychologist Amos Tversky. Kahneman and Tversky calculated a "loss aversion ratio" of 1.5 to 2.5, meaning you would have to gain $15 to $25 to neutralize

the mental pain of losing $10. That explains why we complain when gas rises in price by a dollar a gallon but barely notice when the price falls by the same amount, and why we freak out when the stock market loses 10 percent but don't get very excited when it rises by 10 percent.

The economist Richard Thaler took the idea further with his concept of "myopic loss aversion," which posits that when we are worried about losses, we tend to focus on them a lot, magnifying the issue in our mind. When the economy is tanking, you might add insult to injury by looking every day at your neighborhood gas station's price sign or checking your pension constantly. Perhaps this instinct is a product of the Pleistocene, when your predecessors needed to pay attention to a threat so it didn't kill them. Today, however, it simply means that you have the financial news on all day and walk around with dark circles under your eyes.

Research shows us that financial hardship leads to a vicious cycle of unhappiness: Recession begets misery, which makes for more economic bad times. You naturally make the pattern worse by following your loss-aversion instincts and focusing intently on the prices of gas and food, the estimated value of your house, and the numbers in your retirement account.

If you are wondering whether markets will recover, the answer is almost certainly yes. From World War II to 2021, the stock market has survived nine drops of the current magnitude (20 to 40 percent), and three even greater than this. The markets have recovered and gone on to grow every single time. A better question is how long the recovery will take. On average, declines like the one we are seeing have been erased in 14 to 58 months. It's a fair bet that in a year and a half or so, all this unpleasantness could be in the rearview mirror.

When the economy does come back, you have another opportunity: to solve your recession-unhappiness problem before the next downswing. You can do this by not returning to your old habits that lead to more pain during bear markets than pleasure in bulls. Don't celebrate when stocks go up and gas prices go down. Don't count your money and move up

your retirement date. If you want to end the boom and bust cycles in your happiness, you need to stay just as steady in the good times as you do in the bad. ■

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Behavioural sciences

Nudge factor

Evidence for behavioural interventions looks increasingly shaky

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When economists at the University of Toronto started to tell undergraduates in 2014 how many hours extra work they needed to put in to boost their grades, they hoped it would encourage the students to work harder. They didn't. Instead the students just began to expect the lower grades they received.

The university's experience is frequently quoted as an example of "nudge" theory backfiring. Nudge, the fashionable face of behavioural economics that launched a thousand light-touch government policies, has soared in popularity since the 2008 book of the same name by

Richard Thaler, an economist, and Cass Sunstein, a legal scholar.

There are now more than 200 “nudge” units around the world, teams that specialise in applying behavioural science to everyday life. Nudges seek to persuade rather than compel behaviour change, through a series of psychological strategies, from presenting information in a different way to offering alternatives. As Mr Thaler and Mr Sunstein put it: “Putting fruit at eye level counts as a nudge. Banning junk food does not.”

Nudge theory did not have a great pandemic. Nudge-friendly behavioural scientists were blamed by some for the British government’s initial embrace of soft messaging—appeals to personal responsibility such as the slogan “stay home, save lives”—over strict measures including lockdowns, while a scheme using lotteries with prizes up to $50,000 did little to boost vaccination uptake in Philadelphia.

Nudge fans received some better news at the end of 2021. The first attempt to pool and judge the academic foundations of the theory, more formally known in the field as choice architecture interventions, reported in glowing terms. Psychologists at the University of Geneva analysed some 200 nudge studies and concluded that not only did nudges work overall, but that they did so impressively.

Behavioural scientists judge effect size with a measure called “Cohen’s d”, which shows the difference between the average results in a control and treatment group. A score of zero means that the nudge has made no difference, while anything over 0.8 is considered to indicate a very large effect. The Geneva team said that nudge measures promoted behaviour change with an overall Cohen’s d of 0.43. That places it firmly in the medium-sized category and is more than enough to make most policymakers sit up and take notice.

Other psychologists saw the claims too, and many were unhappy with them. Last week, three separate academic groups, from Britain, Hungary and America, published critiques in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, which also published the Swiss team’s initial analysis.

The complainants make two similar points. First, the academic trials take such different approaches and report such wildly different effect sizes that it does not make sense to bundle them together in the same analysis. A “medium-sized” effect for nudges overall grossly exaggerates the impact of those that are useless and underestimates the benefits of those that work.

Second, nudge research is highly susceptible to publication bias—academic journals tend to favour publishing studies that report the largest effect sizes. After using statistical tools to account for the distorting effect of publication bias, the critics point out that the average effect size from the original analysis collapses, to as low as 0.04, which is effectively useless.

That does not mean that all nudges are ineffective, says Barnabas Szaszi, a psychologist at the University of Budapest and one of the critics. Famously, images of everything from flies to golf flags placed in urinals have been shown to improve men’s aim and reduce cleaning costs. But in such a heterogeneous meta-analysis, those trials of nudge policies that do show significant effects are essentially swamped by the mass of those that don’t. Such meta-analyses, says Mr Szaszi, should break down nudges into smaller distinct groups by type. Only then will policymakers have better ways to measure the effectiveness of different nudge tactics and so learn lessons from the best ones.

“We agree with most of the points raised,” says Ulf Hahnel, one of the Geneva group that carried out the original meta-analysis in 2021. That work did not intend to portray nudges as a silver bullet, he says, and did include caveats about heterogeneity and publication bias.

The controversy emphasises that psychologists and other social scientists need to do more to combat publication bias, the critics say. One ongoing effort asks researchers to pre-register studies before they start, and for journals to agree to publish the results however they fall. Take-up is patchy. Time for a nudge? ■